Instik — Brand Guide

Draft 1 · October 25, 2026 · Status: name chosen; trademark and availability checks still pending

1. Brand essence

Name: Instik (say it: in-STICK)

Where the name comes from: the sound world of *instinct* (second nature), *instant*, and *stick* (the language sticks). It also nods to the feed-style habit we want to replace, without copying it.

Category: a comprehensible-input video platform for picking up languages. Launch language: Egyptian Arabic, with more languages to follow.

The enemy: mindless scrolling, meaning time that disappears and leaves nothing behind.

The promise: your watch time, but it counts.

Mission: turn the time people already spend watching videos into real, measurable language acquisition.

Vision: the place where anyone can pick up any language by watching real people speak it, and where real people can earn a living making that content.

Positioning statement: For adults who want to understand a new language but have 20–60 minutes a day and no teacher, Instik is the video platform that swaps doomscrolling for levelled videos with real hosts, and counts every hour so progress is visible. Unlike apps built on drills, streak pressure and gamification, Instik works the way you got your first language: by understanding.

2. Who we are talking to

Primary audience: adults studying on their own, with English as the interface language. Heritage learners, partners and friends of native speakers, travellers and expats, and fans of a culture's film, music and media.

What they already do: scroll video feeds every day, feel a bit guilty about it, and have tried language apps and quit.

What they want to feel: progress without pressure. Understanding, not being tested.

Not for: children, exam prep, grammar-drill fans.

3. Personality and voice

Personality pairs (check every decision against these)

We are	We are not
Human and real	Synthetic, AI-generated, stock
Warm and patient	Pushy, guilt-tripping
Alive and playful	A textbook
Made for adults	Childish or cartoonish
Honest about progress	Hype (“fluent in 30 days”)
Calm and focused	Loud and addictive

Voice rules

- Short sentences. Everyday words. Talk like a friend who speaks the language, not a teacher.
- Say what is true and specific (hours, stages) rather than big promises.
- Never shame. If someone missed a day, say nothing, or say welcome back.
- A little humour is welcome, especially about scrolling. Never mock the learner.
- Use plain terms: watch, understand, hours, pick up. Avoid: hack, master, crush it, unlock your potential, polyglot, lingo.

Sample lines

- Instead of: “You’re on a 12-day streak! Don’t break it!” → “12 hours of Egyptian Arabic so far. Nice.”
- Instead of: “Time to practise your vocabulary!” → “Your next video is ready when you are.”
- Instead of: “Congratulations, you completed Level 1!” → “You can now follow slow, everyday Egyptian Arabic. That’s real.”
- End-of-session screen: “That’s enough for today. See you tomorrow.”

4. Messaging

Primary tagline

Your scroll time, but it counts.

Alternates (test with strangers)

- Same thumb. Different outcome.
- Scroll less. Understand more.
- Pick up a language. Don't study it.
- Watch it until it sticks.

Landing page hero

- **Headline:** Your scroll time, but it counts.
- **Subhead:** Watch real people speak Egyptian Arabic, at your level, and see every hour add up. No drills. No pressure.
- **Primary button:** Start watching free
- **Secondary line:** More languages coming. Join the waitlist for yours.

Three pillars

1. **Real people.** Native-speaker hosts you can see and name. No synthetic voices, no stock footage. *Proof: host profiles with faces and names.*
2. **At your level.** Videos tagged and recommended so you understand almost everything and pick up the rest from context. *Proof: levels on every video.*
3. **Counted.** Every honest minute of watching is tracked toward a roadmap. *Proof: the hours counter and the stage you are in.*

30-second pitch

You already watch videos every day. Instik turns that habit into a language. We make slow, friendly, levelled videos with real native-speaker hosts, starting with Egyptian Arabic. You watch, you understand a bit more each day, and an hours counter shows your progress. No tests, no streak panic. Just understanding until it sticks.

"Is this AI?" answer (use everywhere)

"No. Every video is made with real native speakers. We use technology to help you understand, not to replace the people you learn from." *(Only publish this if it is always true.)*

Later: the creator message (not for launch headline)

“Make videos that help people understand your language, and get paid for the hours they watch.” Keep this out of the learner-facing homepage until the creator programme exists.

Claims we do not make

- Fluency in a fixed time.
- Anything about results we have not measured.
- Hours thresholds as promises: always call them estimates.

5. Naming system

- **Brand:** Instik. Written with a capital I in sentences, lowercase in the logo.
- **Pronunciation:** in-STICK. Put this on the About page.
- **Product lines:** Instik Egyptian Arabic, Instik Spanish (later), and so on. URLs follow the plan: instik.com/learn/arabic-egyptian.
- **Arabic rendering:** commission a native designer to propose an Arabic wordmark and test spellings with Egyptian speakers. Do not guess the spelling.
- **Learner-facing terms:**
  - **Hours** (the counter)
  - **Roadmap** (the stages)
  - **Hosts** (the people)
  - **Up next** (recommendations)
  - **Done for today** (the end-of-session screen)
- **Stage names (idea to test):** Hear it → Follow it → Understand it → Join in. Keep internal tags (Superbeginner, Beginner) out of learner copy if you can.
- **Micro-moment (test with a native speaker):** a small “فاهم؟ ✓” (“understand?”) check at the end of a video, written in Egyptian Arabic.

6. Visual identity

Logo direction

- **Wordmark first:** lowercase **instik** in a friendly, rounded sans. The brand has to work as a small app icon, so design the icon first.
- **Idea 1:** the dot of the “i” becomes a small play button or speech bubble.
- **Idea 2:** the final “k” has a tail like a speech bubble, so the whole word reads as someone talking.

- **Idea 3:** the two i's as a pair of listening ears or eyes. Test whether it looks silly.
- **Companion Arabic wordmark** designed to sit at the same weight and height.
- **Avoid:** anything that looks like the Instagram camera, its rounded square with a gradient, or its pink-purple-orange colours. Looking too close to Instagram is both a legal risk and a confusion risk.

Colour (starting palette)

Role	Name	Hex
Primary dark	Ink	#1B2340
Primary accent	Coral	#FF6A4D
Background	Cream	#FFF4E6
Secondary accent	Teal	#19A38F
Highlight	Sun	#FFC83D
Secondary text	Slate	#5B6478

- Use Ink text on Cream for reading. Use Coral as a fill, not for small text (white on coral is weak for contrast).
- Check every pair for accessible contrast before you commit.
- Avoid the gold-and-sand look and pyramids, camels and other tourist clichés.

Typography

- **Latin headlines:** a warm, rounded geometric sans (candidates: Nunito, Poppins, DM Sans).
- **Latin body and UI:** a clean, readable sans (candidates: Inter, DM Sans).
- **Arabic:** test for legibility at small sizes **with tashkeel**. Candidates: Cairo, IBM Plex Sans Arabic, Noto Naskh Arabic for transcripts.
- **Rule:** Arabic and Latin are visually balanced in weight and size wherever they appear together. Treat Arabic typography as a brand asset.

Illustration and photography

- **Illustration:** hand-drawn, warm, simple, and consistent with the drawings used in the Superbeginner videos. Builds a recognisable look and avoids stock-app style.
- **Photography:** real hosts, real places, natural light. No stock models.
- **Never:** AI-generated hosts or faces. This would break the brand's central promise.

Motion and sound

- Calm, short, purposeful. No bouncing, no confetti.
- A soft, single sound when an hour is added. Keep it optional.

7. Brand behaviours inside the product

The brand is what the product does. These rules are as important as the logo.

1. **No infinite scroll.** Lists end. Sessions end. The “Done for today” screen is a feature, not a failure.
2. **Honest hours.** Only real watching counts. Say so on the dashboard.
3. **Progress over streaks.** Replace guilt-based streaks with a gentle rhythm view (days you watched), with no loss and no punishment.
4. **No tests by default.** Level check is a friendly choice, not an exam.
5. **Hosts are people.** Every video shows who made it. Host pages with a face and a short story.
6. **Notifications are kind.** Rare, never guilt-based, easy to turn off.
7. **Don’t copy the feed.** Autoplay-next is off by default; the learner chooses the next video.

8. Launch and social

Where to show up

Go where the learners already scroll: Instagram Reels, TikTok and YouTube Shorts. Short clips are the marketing; the full levelled videos are the product.

Content pillars for social

- **“Can you understand this?”** 10-second Egyptian Arabic clips with a visual, then reveal the meaning.
- **Host moments:** short personal clips from the hosts.
- **Scroll swap:** funny, kind content about replacing a scroll habit.
- **Learner milestones:** “I understood my first conversation” (with permission).

Handles

Secure @instik on every platform if possible. If not, choose one consistent fallback (for example @instik.app) and use it everywhere.

First 90 days (outline)

- **Days 1–30:** checks, wordmark and palette locked, waitlist page live, 10 sample videos published on YouTube.
- **Days 31–60:** social clips daily, founding-learner group, collect feedback on level and transliteration.
- **Days 61–90:** soft launch of the platform to waitlist, measure hours watched per learner and 30-day return rate.

9. Risks and checks before you invest

1. **Trademark:** run a search for Instik and anything starting with “Insta” in education and software classes. Meta has history of objecting to “Insta” names. Get legal advice before spending on branding.
2. **Domains and handles:** instik.com, plus common misspellings (instick, instic).
3. **Meaning and sound:** check in Egyptian Arabic, Spanish and each planned language.
4. **Stranger test:** show the name, tagline and logo to 5–10 target learners; ask 24 hours later what they remember and what they think it does. Watch for people who think it is a social network.
5. **Don’t become the thing we replace.** Review every feature against the brand behaviours in section 7.
6. **Creator story timing:** keep the creator message out of the learner homepage until creators exist.

10. Next 30 days

1. Trademark search and domain/handle purchase.
2. Stranger test of name and tagline.
3. Brief a designer: wordmark, icon, Arabic companion, palette, type.
4. Write the About page and host profile template.
5. Decide the transliteration standard (affects every transcript).
6. Publish the first 3 sample videos.
7. Open a waitlist page with the hero copy from section 4.